

Episode 1

Hana

The first catchy bars of CNTR's newest hit, "Summer, Summer" blasted through the little café. It'd only been out a couple days, but it was already the Next Big Thing and I'd heard it upwards of 50 times. I had my hands full juggling multiple orders of double skim lattes, but my body moved smoothly from one step to the next.

Okay, maybe the song was a little catchy.

"Hey, you're a good dancer," my coworker Laura said. "Can you become their back up dancer so you can go on tour with them?"

She sighed dreamily, blowing a kiss to the lead singer who was giant on the overhanging TV of the café. His name was Shin, if I remembered correctly. I should've known, they were sometimes all my best friend Eunji talked about. I did remember that CNTR stood for Center... or Circle or something.

"And give all this up?" I asked.

"Just think about it, Hana!" Laura grinned. "It must be so amazing to be a K-pop star. Traveling the world with your best buds, dancing for millions of adoring fans....Legend has it, CNTR's so amazing that girls faint at every single one of their concerts!"

I scoffed, "It's not all fun and games, y'know. Look at the way they move, how synchronized and clean they are—that's from hours and hours of practice and hard work that goes on behind the scenes."

"Still, it's gotta be better than this," Almost as if on cue, a baby started wailing in line. We made faces at each other.

“I’m not going to be a barista forever, remember? After I graduate, I’m going to get licensed as a psychologist. It’s all in the five-year plan. But—”

“But you have to admit he is hot right?” Laura asked, pointing to the guy rapping on screen.

“Which one is he?”

Laura glared at me. “Jiho!”

I grinned mischievously, “Okay, Jiho is pretty hot.”

“I knew it!” Laura squealed, knocking over a coffee cup in her excitement and I burst into a fit of giggles.

“Excuse me!”

A couple stood fuming behind the counter, both dressed to the nines in brand name clothes. The man snapped his jewel-encrusted fingers at Laura.

“Can you turn this garbage noise off? We were having such a nice morning, and this racket is really ruining it for us.”

I stepped in front of Laura, a plastic smile on my face. “I’m sorry, sir, but this is a popular song right now. And, we’re not playing it very loud. The song will change soon anyway.”

The woman spoke up in a nasal whine, “Well, I don’t like it!”

The owner appeared from his back office, wiping his gleaming, bald head with a handkerchief. In private, we always referred to him as “Bitchin’ Christian.” “So sorry, we’ll turn it off right away.”

“Make sure you do,” the man huffed before grabbing their two double-shot, soy pumpkin spice flat tops and marching away. Christian’s bright smile fell off his face as soon as the two were out of sight.

“How many times do I have to tell you this, Hana? The customer is always right,” he said. “This is the last time I want to catch you arguing with someone, is that clear?”

I nodded mutely, not trusting myself to speak. Christian walked away to the office where he spent the majority of his days, shiny bald head bent over stacks of cash like a fleshy baby dragon.

“Why is he always in such a bad mood? Would it kill him to be nice to me for a change?” I slammed a couple of dirty cups into the sink.

Laura rubbed my back, soothingly, “Don’t worry about it. I always get weird vibes from him, too.”

The worst part of it was, I had to put up with it. This coffee place was so high-end, it paid more than my old café in the city did. Plus, even with all the financial aid NYU was giving me, it was seriously eating up my savings...and New York wasn’t exactly cheap, either. Maybe I needed to take a semester off to save money—I’d looked into it before. I’d just have to turn in the paperwork to make it happen.

Just the thought of working for Christian an extra six months was enough to make me tear up. I abruptly got up and hustled to the coffee machine, busying myself with another espresso order. Busy hands, no bad thoughts, my mother always used to say.

Then, the doorbell jingled and two tall men wearing hats and sunglasses walked in.

Jiho

Ordinarily, I wasn't a coffee guy. I was a Korean who preferred boricha, or barley tea. Even the smell of coffee could make me nauseous. I glanced at Doyoon in his sunglasses next to me. He had insisted on going to this posh café that supposedly had the best Americanos in all of New York, and, being the good hyung that I was, I'd let him have his way.

We squeezed into a table at the front of the shop by the window. A bit risky, but this was New York City, I supposed.

"When are you going to tell me why you're acting so strange?" I asked.

Doyoon pulled his sunglasses part of the way down. "How do you know that?"

I gave him a look. "We trained together, have been on tour for three years and I'm not supposed to know when my best friend is acting weird?" I asked. "Out with it."

He took his sunglasses off and blew his silky black locks away from his eyes. "Look, I know how important the VMA's are to us—" He cut himself off, then looked at me. "But I'm not sure I can do it."

"You're not going to perform?" I blurted.

"That's not what I'm saying! I never said that I wouldn't perform," he said. "Maybe if you stopped interrupting me and listened for once, you'd figure that out."

"It doesn't matter what you want anyway. We're all under contract to perform when the company wants us to, whether we like it or not."

Doyoon poked his tongue out at me as he put his sunglasses back on. “You just don’t want any trouble because you’re the leader and it would look like you can’t control your team.”

He wasn’t completely wrong, but I bristled at the accusation anyway. As the leader, I was responsible for keeping the group in line and Doyoon knew it. I hadn’t exactly wanted the role, but I’d done it to protect them—DJ Entertainment treated us nicely so long as CNTR was performing well, but most of them didn’t know about the entertainment company’s dark side. It was a side that I knew far too well.

“That’s not it. I’m your hyung, we’re brothers. I’m supposed to look out for you.” I looked away from Doyoon’s questioning gaze, squinting at some artsy, minimalist photo on the wall instead. “I—we all want you to be happy, that’s all.”

Doyoon muttered under his breath, “If you really cared about my happiness, you’d never have had us come to New York.”

Hana

“You’re Korean, right? What are they talking about?” Laura whispered excitedly in my ear.

I swatted at Laura, shaking my head. “Just because I’m Korean doesn’t mean I can speak it. It’s none of our business anyway. Let’s just go back to work.”

Despite what I’d said, I couldn’t help but eavesdrop a tiny bit. Even though both their faces were mostly covered by their giant sunglasses, it was easy to tell that both men were extraordinarily handsome. The taller one spoke in a low, velvet voice that was oddly familiar—I could listen to him talk for days.

It was hard to follow their conversation, but getting easier now that they were getting in line for something instead of loitering at a table. The two spoke in rapid-fire Korean, and the only time I spoke the language anymore was with my best friend Eunji or her family. Speaking Korean was a painful reminder of the life I used to have before the car crash that had killed my parents three years ago.

“Stop telling me what to do! You can’t just boss people around like this!” The shorter man jabbed his finger into the taller one’s chest, but he was quickly brushed off.

“That’s not what I’m doing! But I guess I can’t expect you to be anything but a naive little kid,” the taller one mocked. I almost expected the sunglasses to melt off the shorter guy’s face, and I cut in hurriedly before they could get into an all-out fistfight and wreck the store. No doubt Christian would find some way to blame me for it.

“Morning! What can I get you?” I asked quickly in English. Speak of the devil. The argument had lured Christian out from his office cave, and I could see his pasty egghead, lurking out of the corner of my eye, waiting for me to make a mistake. “Hello? Excuse me, can I take your order?”

The two men continued bickering, completely unaware of my existence. Meanwhile, the line of customers behind them grew longer and Christian drew ever closer.

Desperate, I blurted, “Look guys, if you don’t want to order, maybe you can take your argument outside? I’ve got other customers to serve.”

This time, the taller one of the two gave me a quick glare before diving right back into his rant. Anger rose up in me, quick as a snake, but I fought it down. I’d already gotten into one fight with a customer today; Christian might actually fire me if I yelled at somebody else.

I mustered up my best 100-watt smile before trying again. “Would you like some recommendations today? Cappuccino is our specialty.”

The tall one finally turned to me, his flawless English dripping with disdain. “Didn’t your parents ever teach you not to interrupt?”

He rolled his eyes at the guy with him and muttered in Korean, “God, she’s so annoying. She should mind her own damn business.”

That was the last straw. The anger I’d been bottling up inside all day broke through and I spat back in Korean, “You guys are the annoying ones! I’m telling you to move because you’re holding up the whole line! What makes you so special, huh?”

Although he’d been momentarily stunned into silence, the man quickly recovered his trademark sneer, “At least I don’t work in a coffee shop.”

I saw red. Without even thinking about it, I grabbed the closest glass and threw its contents toward his stupid, arrogant face. The water formed a perfect, glistening arc in the air and the whole coffee shop seemed to hold their breath as it drenched his designer coat.

Rough hands grabbed me out of the way, and the last thing I saw before I stumbled backward was a sweaty, glistening, bald head.

Episode 2

Jiho

I watched the water flying at me in horror. My shirt—my \$500 St. Laurent T-shirt!—was drenched instantly, and all I could do was stand, gawking like a fish while water dripped all over the marbled floor.

There was a stunned silence for a beat or two, then Doyoon burst out into hyena-like cackles, his entire body shaking from the force of his laughs.

“Hyung, it looks like you went for a swim!” he blabbered, wiping a single tear from his eye.

I glared at the barista, who was still standing there, frozen, with the empty glass in her hand. Horror and triumph mixed on her face, her pretty mouth shaping itself into a little “o” of disbelief.

A hot, coiling snake of rage roared up inside me, and everything turned red. How dare this girl throw water on me? Who did she think she was?

Curse words spilled from my tongue like a flood. Distantly, I could hear someone yelling, “Barista-sekiya! You piece of shit! Dol-a-ee! You rock-headed idiot!” The barrage of insults only stopped when a hand slapped itself over my mouth.

Doyoon.

“We better get going,” He sounded strained, his normal, affable expression pinched in stress.

I shook his hand off with a growl, muttering, “If you touch me again, I’ll kill you.”

He took two steps back with both hands up in the air and I took a deep, cleansing breath before forcing myself to face the insolent barista.

“Thanks for nothing,” I snapped, completely ignoring her coworker who’d turned white and was babbling apologies behind her. Doyoon grabbed my arm and nearly dragged me out the door.

Before the door closed, I caught one last look at the barista, at the proud set of her shoulders, and her delicate olive skin flushed red. Her eyes were still defiant in the face of the furious, bald giant that towered over her. Something inside of me twinged.

Then, the door shut behind me.

Hana

Christian didn't even wait for the two assholes to leave before pulling me behind the espresso machine, virtually shoving me into a corner where the other customers wouldn't be able to see him give me the ass whooping of the century. His voice shook from the effort it took to keep it down.

"Hana Kyung, what did I tell you literally five minutes ago?"

"You saw what happened out there! He was holding up the line and then he started insulting me—"

"Hana. What. Did. I. Tell. You?"

I sucked in a breath, "That the customer is always right."

Christian slapped the chrome side of the espresso machine with a loud thud. I flinched. "The customer is always right. Always. And that makes you wrong. What in the hell were you thinking, throwing water on someone like that?"

"I guess I wasn't thinking at all. I'm...sorry." I managed to push out an apology through my clenched teeth. Christian stooped down, cupping one ear out toward me.

"What was that?"

“Sorry. I’m sorry!” I burst out, although it killed a little part inside of me to say it. I just had to get through crap like this for my five-year plan... “I went overboard. I shouldn’t have done it, and I promise, it’ll never happen again.”

“You bet your ass it won’t. You’re fired.”

Christian drew out the “f,” savoring each syllable, with his mouth curved up in the closest semblance of a smile I’d ever seen on his brutish face. I gasped, frantically clutching at his sleeve. He shook me off with a disgusted look.

“B-but I’ve always been on time, every day for the past year, and aside from this incident I haven’t made any trouble—”

Christian scoffed, cutting me off, “You? No trouble? Don’t kid yourself. Honestly, I should have fired you months ago, but I kept giving you chances out of the kindness of my heart,” he said. “Save your breath and leave with some dignity. I’ll send you your last paycheck in the mail, so don’t even think about coming back. Ever.”

Before I could say another word he was gone, probably back into his office cave to gleefully cross my name out from next week’s schedule.

Fine. If he was going to be an ass, so would I. I untied my barista apron and threw it on the ground, stomping on it a bit for good measure. I was just turning to the expensive coffee beans that Christian had special ordered from an exotic village in Colombia when Laura ran up to me, breathless.

“Ohmigod, Hana, do you know who you just threw water on?”

“No, and I don’t want to know,” I said. “Christian just fired me, Laura. I’ve got other things to worry about.”

“What? No...he couldn’t have!” Her hands flew to her mouth, but the shock seemed a little too exaggerated to be real.

I narrowed my eyes. “You don’t seem that surprised.”

“I mean—you just threw water over Jiho! Jiho from CNTR!” The words came out in a rush between her pants of excitement. I’d thrown water on a K-pop star?

I waited for something to hit me—some kind of fear, or horror, or even pride that I’d shown up an arrogant celebrity—but nothing came but a kind of bone-deep weariness. Rent’s due, I thought distantly. And now I didn’t know how I was going to pay up.

“I’ve got to go, Laura.” I picked my bag up off the floor and turned my back on Laura and Christian and the coffee shop from hell, the bell ringing out a farewell chime as I strode off into the concrete jungle.

Jiho

People have this glamorous idea in their heads of what show business is like. They think that stars are pampered every minute of their lives, showered with attention from dedicated assistants and luxurious gifts from admirers. And sometimes they’re right.

But behind every seemingly flawless performance, every pitch-perfect note, were endless hours of practice. CNTR had paid for our fame, pound for pound, in blood, sweat, and tears.

I scanned all the different performers who were warming up before it was their turn to rehearse on the big stage. Some I recognized from the posters that were hanging on my childhood bedroom wall, while others, like us, had risen through the ranks only a short

time ago. The only thing that we had in common was that everyone was instantly recognizable. All of us famous in some way. All of us A-listers.

ZT watched the movement on the stage, his brown hair catching the light. “This is the VMA’s.” His eyes were wide. “What the hell are we doing here, man?” he whispered to me.

I punched his shoulder lightly. “Don’t you start talking like that. They wouldn’t have let us in if we didn’t deserve to be here.”

The show’s producer stuck his head into our dressing room and held up five fingers. Five minutes until our turn on the big stage.

“We’re going after Ariana Grande?” ZT sounded terrified. The producer winked, giving us a thumbs up before disappearing into the whirl of stagehands prepping the stage for our set.

“Okay guys!” I clapped my hands. All four heads turned to me. “You heard the man. I say we run through ‘Can’t Catch Me’ one more time—”

LEO groaned. “We’ve practiced that one a million times, hyung. One more time isn’t going to change anything at this point.”

ZT nodded, and LEO shot me a cocky grin at his little insubordination. He did have a point though—we did know every song backward and forward, and maybe it’d be good to let the guys have a bit of a break so we could be fresh. I sighed, then held up my hands. Fine.

“Thank you, thank you very much,” LEO purred in his best Elvis impression, gyrating his hips and slicking back his hair just like The King.

“Wait, are those my sunglasses?” ZT pointed to the pair of Gucci sunnies perched on LEO’s nose.

“No,” LEO said, too quickly.

I tuned out the rest of their squabble to concentrate on the new lyrics for our next album instead. Every time I thought I was onto something, though, the barista’s angry, accusing eyes floated in front of me, completely interrupting my train of thought.

“Distracted?”

“Get out of here Doyoon. I’m busy,” I snapped, although there was no real fire behind it. Doyoon raised his brow and gestured toward my notebook, where I’d absentmindedly sketched out a face with a vague resemblance to Coffee Shop Girl. One look at Doyoon and I knew he was thinking the same thing.

“You know,” he started thoughtfully, tapping the notebook, “You seem a little hung up on that gi—that incident.”

“No way, man.” The girl seemed to look at me skeptically from the page, “You sure about that, buddy?”

“You shouldn’t have yelled at her like that. Hate to admit it, hyung, but you were acting like those reality show celebs, the ones that treat people like dirt.”

“Drama queen much, Doyoon? It really wasn’t that big of a deal.”

He shook his head, his eyes sad. “There was a time when you never would have yelled at someone the way you just yelled at that girl. You’re a good guy Jiho, but I think you forget that sometimes.”

A knot tightened deep in my core—regret? Guilt?—and I slammed my notebook shut.

“You know what? Some things change, Doyoon, in case you haven’t noticed,” I snarled, gesturing around at the beautiful people, the stagehands scurrying about. Doyoon’s face hardened.

“Well, I hope I never become like you,” he said. “I’ll never treat people the way you do, as if they’re garbage.”

Movement caught the corner of my eye and we both turned to see Shin waving his hands at us frantically from the door, motioning toward the waiting show producer.

“Whatever, man. It’s time to go,” I brushed past Doyoon, accidentally-on-purpose knocking him out of the way. All five of us headed to the awaiting stage, the silence between us thick with nerves. Even LEO was quiet, a feat I’d once thought impossible. Shin was just pulling back the curtain when—

“Wait!” Junghoon sprinted toward us from the end of the hall, flashing his “MANAGER” badge at any bewildered assistants that tried to stop him. He brandished a phone in front of him like it was an active bomb.

“What is it?” Shin stepped toward him, but our manager blew past, nearly slapping me in the face with his phone.

“Calm down!” I tried to back away, but Junghoon grabbed me before I could move any farther.

“You!” he hissed, pushing play on the video before shoving the screen in front of me. “You endless pain in my ass.”

“Excuse me?” I asked, but he shushed me and gestured toward the video where a miniature version of Coffee Shop Girl was splashing a very tiny, very angry Jiho. My heart sunk to the bottom of my stomach.

“Oh.” The tiny backstage area was filled with the tinny recording of my outburst and the other members looked at me in horror. Shibai. Dol-a-ee. Doyoon was right—it had been way worse than I’d thought.

“Oh? Oh? Is that all you have to say for yourself?” Our manager demanded, an angry god to my repentant sinner. “How are we going to explain this?!”

Episode 3

Hana

My favorite bar in Williamsburg was indistinguishable from all the other grungy, industrial-chic joints that cluttered the neighborhood, but the prices were infinitely cheaper and the bartenders could care less about how much you spent, as long as you didn’t bother them. The regulars were mean, even by New York standards, the bathrooms were disgusting, and everything smelled like old grapes.

I loved it.

But tonight, I couldn’t even taste the beer that was growing warm in my hands. Eunji sighed, reached over, and gave me a quick side hug from the seat next to me. I leaned into her comforting warmth, and when she finally pulled away, our matching friendship bracelets got caught on each other.

“Do you remember when I gave you this?” She asked while she reached down to untangle them.

I took another half-hearted sip of my beer. “Of course, I do. Three years ago, this month.”

Eunji looked at me, pride shining from her eyes. “I knew I wanted you in my corner. You’ve never taken crap from anybody, that’s what I love about you. And don’t tell anybody from the fan club, but it honestly sounds like Jiho deserved it.”

I still couldn’t quite wrap my head around the fact that I’d thrown water in a K-pop star’s face. Or that I’d yelled at him. Or that I couldn’t get his irritating face out of my mind.

“Seriously?” I asked. “But you love CNTR.”

“But I love you more,” Eunji said, clinking her glass with mine. “Jiho might be the hottest rapper with a jawline that doesn’t quit—” I snorted, “—but a jawline and a voice like butter aren’t everything.”

“Thanks, Jiji.” I smiled at my beautiful best friend, letting her soft words of comfort soothe me for a bit.

“That’s friendship, girl.”

“But what am I going to do about rent? I need a new job, pronto.”

“I’ll think of something. You know I’ve got your back.” She downed the rest of her old-fashioned in one gulp and set the empty glass down with a satisfied smack. “By the way, did anything end up happening after that night with the cute guy? Whatshisname—Miles?”

Miles, a guy from the dance crew I was in, came to mind, but his soft brown eyes and kind smile morphed into devilish black ones and an arrogant sneer. I shook my head, disturbed. Why am I thinking of him?

Eunji was still watching me curiously, so I offered up a weak smile for her sake. “Like I have time to worry about guys right now,” I said. “I’m unemployed, Jiji! Soon to be apartmentless! In New York City!”

“You need to lighten up a little bit. You’re wasting your life working 70 hours a week and barely seeing your friends,” she said. “Miles is...well, not hot, but he’s really cute. And that body!” She blew a chef’s kiss into the air and I giggled in spite of myself.

“Fine. I’ll text him, okay?” I grinned. “Now, buy your poor friend a drink!”

Glowing with pleasure at my surrender, she graciously waved a bartender over to order another old-fashioned and a fresh lager. In between sips, she casually threw out, “Oh, my mom was wondering when you were coming over for brunch next.”

Great. I took a deep pull of my drink, suddenly feeling the need to get very, very drunk.

Jiho

The rehearsal passed by in a blur. I faintly remembered going through the motions, as if in a dream, my body automatically twisting and turning through the complicated steps as the harsh lights above me turned from red to yellow to blue. Then the other members were surrounding me, the producer motioning for the next team while giving us high-fives.

The entire time, all I could see was the burning anger in the barista’s eyes as she threw the water, an anger that felt so familiar to me. Her rage had been a twin flame to my own.

The car dropped us off at our hotel, and I made a beeline for my hotel room. Knowing I wouldn’t be able to relax after a day like today, I did the only thing that ever calmed me down sometimes—practice. Luckily, my hotel room was ritzy as hell, complete with a giant whirlpool, floor-to-ceiling windows, and a giant, full-length mirror that covered the entire back wall.

As soon as I pressed play on our newest song, the feel of cold water on my face and the smell of coffee faded away. It was just me and the music and the dance. Uncomplicated. Easy. My breaths turned into pants and sweat dripped into the lush gray carpet as I lunged and stepped and flipped.

By the time I got to my rap solo, my entire body was trembling with exertion, but the words spit out of me like gunfire. It was easy to fuel every word with the acid that had churned in my stomach ever since Junghoon had shown me the video.

A shrill ring interrupted the music. I cursed and gave the screen a cursory glance, ready to end the call when I noticed the caller ID. Mr. Song.

Crap! The CEO of DJ Entertainment was one of the most powerful men in the entertainment world. He was not a man you wanted to get a personal call from at—I checked my watch—approximately 2 a.m. Seoul time. I gulped, then accepted the call.

“Jiho! How are you my boy? Is New York to your liking?” Mr. Song’s voice was warm, almost jovial. The voice of a kind father checking in with a beloved son. I knew better than to fall for his act.

DJ Entertainment was one of the most ruthless corporations that existed in the music world, renowned for using unscrupulous tactics on both their entertainers and competitors alike. And at its head was Mr. Song—its brutal general. Even knowing that, though, it was hard to keep my guard up around him; it just felt wrong to distrust a man that sounded so genuinely curious about how I was doing.

“Yeah, I guess. I mean, it’s been fantastic, sir. Thank you for all the amazing accommodations.”

“Of course. It’s the least we could do for our VMA nominees.” Was that a real hint of pride in his voice? “You and the rest of the crew are still rehearsing every day, I hope?”

“Morning, noon, and night.”

“Good, good. We’re planning to drop CNTR’s new music video next week so we can time it with the MTV momentum you’ve got going.”

“That sound good, sir.”

“I expect you boys to give an out-of-this-world performance. No one’s going to want to buy a new album from a band that flops. You fail at the Awards, and you can pretty much say good-bye to seeing the top of the charts for a long, long time.”

I grit my teeth. “We’ll kill it out there, sir. That’s a promise.”

“Good. As the leader, I’m counting on you to really knock that into that group of yours. Ah! That reminds me,” a serious inflection slipped into his voice, “Like it or not, these boys look up to you, both on and off the stage. All the trainees here, hell—the world—looks up to you.”

The air was thick with disapproval. It was amazing how he could make me feel like a little kid again from thousands of meters away. “I understand, Mr. Song. I really do, and I want to thank you for this leadership role—”

“I gave you this opportunity because I knew you could do it. I see the potential in you, son. Always have. And I’d hate to see all that potential go down the drain. If I see any more embarrassing videos of you, well, we might just have to look at other options.”

He said it mildly, as if he was just mulling over what he was going to eat for a midnight snack. But the threat coiled like a snake around my throat, choking me with sudden fear. That damn barista. This is all her fault!

“Of...of course, sir. It was a mistake on my part and it will never happen again.”

The door creaked behind me, and Doyoon suddenly appeared by my side, his eyes wide.

“See to it that it doesn’t.” The CEO’s tone changed again, dripping once more with the warmth of a doting father. “I have high hopes for you, my boy.”

“I won’t disappoint you, sir.”

Beep-beep-beep. The call ended, and Doyoon whistled.

“Whoa. Was that the big boss?”

“Mr. Song? Yeah.”

“What was he calling about?” Doyoon asked in a way that made it perfectly clear he knew exactly what the call had been about.

“Same old, same old. Are we practicing until our feet fall off, are we making progress on the new album, why did I cuss out a barista in the middle of New York...”

Doyoon made a face. “I mean, you can’t tell me you’re surprised. We’re stars now. You can’t go pulling stuff like that and not expect to get noticed. I doubt anything’s going to happen to you. Celebs do this kind of shit all the time and you’re the head of a chart-topping phenomenon. Song can’t touch you.”

Great. Doyoon was right. The leader of CNTR...losing his mind inside a coffee shop? That kind of thing was definitely going to go viral, and now I’d made the whole group look like egotistical assholes.

“Doyoon. What do I do now?” I asked so softly, I could barely hear myself. Out of the corner of my eye, I could see a sweet smile spreading like the sun over his face.

“Hyung, I’d apologize.”

I slept fitfully that night, my dreams of a proud woman with fiery eyes drowned out by visions of black adders squeezing my arms and legs, whispering about other options. It was still dark when I gave up on sleep altogether, grabbed a bland gray tracksuit and headed to the gym. It was completely empty at this hour, so I clambered up on the best treadmill they had, and the meters fell away beneath my feet.

Then the phone rang.

Not again, I groaned inwardly, Mr. Song’s threats from yesterday still reverberating in my ears. But I brightened when I saw who it was.

“Jihee!” I answered warmly. I could always count on my older sister to bring a smile to my face. “To what do I owe the pleasure?”

“Your stupidity,” I winced at the unexpected bitterness in her voice. “What the hell were you thinking, yelling at that poor girl like that? The video is all the netizens are talking about over here.”

So much for starting the day off with a couple of laughs. “I wasn’t thinking anything at all. Doyoon had just told me he wasn’t happy and,” I dropped to a whisper, “Jihee, I think he wants to leave the group! I freaked out.”

“It doesn’t excuse you taking it out on a barista.”

“I know that!” I threw my hands up in the air. Would I never hear the end of this stupid incident?

“Don’t get mad. You know, we’re all so proud of you and seeing you get torn apart over something like this hurts us, too. Did I tell you Mom and Dad even put up a banner of you in their store?”

“No. I didn’t know that.” Hot guilt flushed through me. I hadn’t even considered that my blow-up would affect my family too. “Look, can you tell them I’m sorry? That I know I did something bad and I’m going to fix it.”

“Okay, I’ll let them know. Why were you in a coffee shop anyway? I thought you hated the stuff. Who are you and what have you done with my little bro?”

“Har-har. It’s a long story. Don’t you have to get back to studying for your pharmacy exam or something?”

“Trying to get rid of me so soon?”

“It’s not that. I’ve got rehearsal in ten,” I lied.

“Fine. But call more! We miss you, okay? Mom and Dad are always complaining they never hear from you anymore.”

“Yeah, I promise. Love you.” I ended the call and strode out of the gym, almost running back to my hotel room. If I hurried, I had just enough time before practice to fix this mess.

Twenty minutes and a quick shower later, I rushed out of my cab onto the bustling New York street. The gleaming café stood in front of me, its giant awning and windows staring down accusingly, as if to ask how I dared to step into its premises again.

Don’t be melodramatic.

Before I could lose my nerve, I pushed open the door and walked right up to the counter, ignoring the indignant cries and gasps of all the people in line.

“Listen, I was here yesterday and just wanted to say...” I trailed off as I nudged past the person being served and came face-to-face with a very confused barista. A brass name badge with “CHARLIE” emblazoned on the front winked from his chest.

“Uh...I’m sorry, sir, but you’re going to have to wait in line if you want a coffee,” he stuttered.

I peeked over his shoulder but there was no tell-tale, light brown ponytail behind him. “Where’s the girl barista that was here yesterday? Brown hair, wears it in a ponytail, light brown eyes?” Almost gold, I thought. They would have been enchanting in any other situation.

“You mean Hana? I have no idea. I was hired yesterday after she was fired.” He dropped his voice conspiratorially, “I heard she threw water at some really famous guy.”

The girl ended up getting fired, huh? Well, it was a customer service job and she did lose her temper at a paying guest. Not to mention the amount of water she’d thrown on him—what had she been trying to do, drown him? Anyone would say she deserved to lose her job in this situation.

But, a tiny voice whispered, you started it and you were the one who took it that far.

Charlie cleared his throat. “Do you want a coffee or—?”

“No...thanks though.” I turned to leave, then paused. “Actually, do you know where I might be able to find her?”

Episode 4

Jiho

Another day, another grueling rehearsal. The closer the VMA's got, the worse we seemed to get. ZT was fumbling moves we'd learned in middle school, LEO was mixing up the cues, and even golden boy Shin was singing flat. Each time we had to restart our set, my throat constricted a little more, with Mr. Song's warnings ringing in my ears.

I sighed as the limo drew up to the curb outside our rehearsal space. It swerved twice to avoid a couple particularly determined fans.

"Good lord, do they ever leave?" Shin peered out the tinted windows at the street packed with screaming fans.

"What's your problem, Shin? Can't handle all the cuties out there?" LEO grinned, rolling his window down to blow a kiss to the crowd. A girl holding a "Marry me, Jiho!" sign swooned, nearly falling backward into a circle of her friends.

"Ah. Hurts when women aren't loyal, huh hyung?" LEO winked at me.

"Shut up LEO-sekiya. It's time to go."

I plastered on my giga-watt smile, took a deep breath, and stepped out into the crowd. The screaming hit a fever pitch and our bodyguards strained to keep the moving mass of bodies away. We managed to slip through the crush like minnows in a stream, stopping here and there to sign a couple autographs and take a few selfies. I made sure to take my time. After yesterday, I needed all the positive PR I could get. Still, I couldn't help but make sure to take a selfie with the girl who'd fainted, winking at LEO.

Then, I saw a fountain a few meters away and a flash of inspiration struck me. I waded through the mass of fans, hopped up on the ledge and clapped my hands. Every eye turned. The screaming died. A sea of phones rippled from below, waiting for my next move.

“Everyone! Thank you so much for coming out and supporting us. We love you! Saranghae! We’re nothing without you!”

A roar of approval rose, so loud the stones seemed to shake. Emboldened, I continued, “We’re doing everything we can to make sure our show is spectacular. More than anything, we want to make you proud. I don’t want to let a single one of you down.”

“You sure let us down yesterday!” A girl in a ponytail shouted from my left. She was carrying a sign like some of the other fans, but hers made my heart sink: “Baristas are people too!” The people around her carried similar ones: “Jiho miwuh/We hate you Jiho,” “Fame isn’t everything,” and “Oppa, why?” All of them were wearing ponytails.

“Shut up!” screamed a girl covered head-to-toe in CNTR merch. “Anyone can have a bad day! You’re just jealous!”

The leader of the ponytails launched herself at her before she could finish, closely followed into the fray by her friends nearby. The CNTR girl howled in pain as she slapped the offender away, one hand clasped to her bleeding cheek.

Chaos. Instantly, the orderly crowd of adoring fans devolved into mayhem, each side intent on destroying the other. I peered helplessly over the whirlwind of fists to see where my crew had gone. Hopefully they’re safe.

A large hand pulled me backward into a protective human barrier made up of my security team. We shuffled together toward the entrance of our rehearsal space, but I grasped at one of them, shaking my head desperately.

“We can’t go inside yet! My group is still out there!”

“Everyone’s inside, sir, waiting for you!”

They all but threw me inside the theater where, true to their word, the rest of CNTR was waiting for me in the lobby. I let out a breath I hadn't known I'd been holding.

"Thank god you guys are okay."

"We made it inside right when it started getting crazy. The security guys really know their stuff. But you were in the thick of it—are you okay?" Shin gave a pointed glance at my T-shirt. To my surprise, it could barely be called a T-shirt anymore—the whole thing had been ripped to shreds.

"I'm fine, just a couple of overexcited fans, no big deal."

"Sure, no big deal." Doyoon scoffed, rolling his eyes. Before anyone could respond, he stalked off down the hall to the stage where our choreographer was waiting.

"That was weird," Shin remarked, running a hand through his short blond hair. "But he has a point. Jiho's alive and well, and we really have to go practice now."

We all followed Doyoon to the back, ZT stage-whispering, "I heard the choreographer's pissed at us. One of the assistants overheard him talking about how he's going to put oxygen in our water to get us to perform better or something."

Shin stretched, his graceful hands easily touching his toes before sliding into a perfect downward dog. "If you need a little pick-me-up, I have a new energy drink coming out soon. It's not like that Red Bull stuff—it's got all the electrolytes and stuff you need to actually function better. I'll send a case over to your place."

LEO snorted, "Jesus. I don't get why you're so proud of this stuff. It's not like you did anything other than put your face on it!"

Their argument was loud enough for me to sit down next to Doyoon while he stretched in silence in the corner of the theater.

“Hey,” I cleared my throat. I’d never been good at this kind of touchy-feely talk. “I never asked you if you were okay?”

Doyoon muttered a quiet, “I’m fine,” his eyes never leaving the ground.

“You got to admit that wasn’t very believable.”

“Just...” Doyoon finally turned to look at me but he was a million kilometers away, staring at something in the distance I couldn’t see. “Have you ever thought of walking away from all of this?”

He gestured toward the wrestling Shin and LEO, the choreographer whose face was steadily turning as red as an apple, and at the bustling assistants nearby. “The money, the fame, the fans, the music. Do you ever wonder if it’s worth it?”

I didn’t tell him that sometimes I still felt the gnawing pit of hunger deep in my belly, with only expired food from Dad’s run-down gas station store to fill it. I didn’t tell him that I thought of debt collectors often, big men with tattoos and scars and the pungent aroma of soju floating around them like a miasma. Maybe if I had, I could have stopped what happened next.

But instead, like an idiot, I asked him, “What do you mean? How could it not be worth it?”

Doyoon opened his mouth, but the choreographer’s yell of frustration interrupted whatever he was going to say.

“Come on, he might actually kill us if we don’t start dancing right now,” he said wryly, and I nodded.

Hana

Brunch with the Chos was always the same. Eunji's mother would never fail to comment on how skinny I'd gotten before unveiling a mouthwatering spread of homemade Korean delicacies—bulgogi, crispy seafood pancakes, sushi rolls or gimbab, broiled fish with scales so crispy they crackled at the slightest touch, spicy rice cakes, and a veritable banquet of side dishes.

After we all ate our fill and Eunji's mother had served dessert—fresh Korean pears cut into perfect slices and little butter cookies, arranged just so—was the part that I always dreaded most. The inevitable moment when Eunji's parents would launch in a tirade of all their daughter's shortcomings. They begged me for guidance, my intervention, anything to bring Eunji back to the light.

"I mean, honestly! Who goes to school for fashion? If you want any sort of future, you've got to go to study something legitimate. Just look at Hana!" Eunji's father harrumphed, shoving a whole pear slice into his mouth.

"You know what, dear, you really should go and visit your grandma in Seoul. Your poor halmeoni is probably dying to see you," her mother implored.

Eunji snorted, "What, so someone else can tell me how disappointed they are that I'm wasting my life doing what I love when I could be a doctor or a lawyer instead? Thanks, but no thanks."

Her mother turned her pleading eyes to me and I winced, shrugging helplessly.

"Whatever, guys. Thanks for brunch but Hana has to go study, okay? I'm going to see her out!" Eunji all but ran out of the house, pulling me along with her.

"You know, you can stand to be nicer to them. It's nice that they love you and worry about you like that."

“Listen, Hana, I get that you miss your parents like crazy, okay? And I know I can seem ungrateful. But I love fashion like you love dancing, it’s what gives my life meaning,” Eunji said. “When I see someone’s eyes light up after I’ve styled them, or I’m making an outfit that only existed in my dreams come to life beneath my fingertips—that’s when I feel alive. I can’t just give that up without even trying.”

I pulled her into a bear hug before she could dissolve into tears. “I know, Jiji. I’m proud of you.”

She gave me a sad little smile. “You know, you could chase your dreams with me. Really commit to dance, once and for all. It’s not too late!”

“You know I can’t do that. I love it, but I can’t make a living out of it.” I looked back at the house, where Eunji’s parents were watching us from the window. “I’m all I’ve got now. I’ve got to be realistic about this.”

Jiho

I slammed a shot glass onto the glossy VIP table, nearly spilling its contents all over LEO’s blazer.

“Watch it! This is Alexander McQueen,” he hissed, snatching it up to make sure his precious jacket was safe.

“At least I’m drinking. At a club. Where we are currently at,” I nudged the book on ZT’s lap. ZT swatted me away, rearranging the pages so he could see more in the low light.

“Seriously, man. How are you reading right now, with all these hot girls everywhere?” LEO eyed two leggy blondes dressed in tight tube skirts that left nothing to the imagination.

“Leave me alone! I’m just prepping for my next career move, dude.”

“I totally get it,” Shin nodded sagely. “That’s why I’m launching my new cologne label next month.”

We all burst out in laughter.

“Who wants to smell like you?” LEO cackled.

“Aw, give him a break. Maybe some of our preteen fans’ll be interested,” I grinned.

“Ha-ha. Laugh it up while you can, boys, because in a couple years when I’m at the top, running my own empire, you’ll be the ones begging me for a job.”

“Maybe I should start thinking about my next move, too,” LEO mused. “What about modeling? I think I’d be great for soju, whaddaya think?”

He posed with one of the half-drunk bottles off our table, a goofy grin plastered on his face as he gave the soju a big thumbs-up.

“Considering you’re too young to drink, you might want to try it with Chilsung Cider first.”

I grabbed my soju back from him and the rest of the guys oohed.

“As for the rest of us, why don’t we go a little crazy tonight?” Everyone—including LEO with a bottle of nonalcoholic cider—held up their bottles, “To the VMA’s—may we kill it on stage and show the other bands what a real performance looks like! Gumbae!”

We all chugged our drinks dry. When ZT turned to ask a waitress for another round, I took the chance to whisper to Doyoon under my breath, “And don’t think I’ve forgotten about you.”

“I told you, I’m fine.”

“You haven’t said a single word all night. I really want to talk about what you said—”

A sudden hush fell over the bar. Almost all the men near the entrance had stopped talking, a couple even got up to have a proper look at the person who was causing all the commotion up front. Doyoon’s mouth fell open.

“Hyung, look.”

“What?” I asked irritably, swiveling around to try and spot what was going on.

Then I saw her. Hair as dark and luscious as night, a body that could stop traffic, eyes that seemed to swallow you in their depths and wicked lips to match. She’d paired her priceless limited edition Jimmy Choos with a shabby Gucci sweatshirt, creating an aura of wealth that was as effortless as it was potent.

Wait a minute... I knew her.

“Rachel?”

Episode 5

Jiho

Rachel turned at the sound of her name.

“Oppa!” She beamed, sashaying her way to the group with a sway that made every single guy in her vicinity drool. I wrapped her up in a bear hug. Smoke, tinged with iris and violet, filled my nose—Le Labou Santal 33, her signature scent.

“What are you doing here? I thought you were still at that shoot in Paris?”

“I was, but when I saw you were in New York I just had to drop everything and come see you! Besides, it’s a lot faster to fly to New York from Paris than it is to fly all the way back to Seoul.”

She snapped her fingers at a passing waitress. “Hello? I’m still waiting for my drink?” Rolling her eyes, she stage-whispered, “So hard to find good help these days. Anyway, I just really, really wanted to see you!”

I threw a quick apology glance behind her back to the frazzled waitress before leading her to a seat next to me on the chaise. “I’m happy to see you too, Rach, but you know you didn’t have to do that. Your career’s important, too.”

She arched a graceful eyebrow. “You can’t really believe that. There’ll be plenty of other shoots in the future. How do you think it looks to your bajillion fans out there if I’m not here to support my superstar boyfriend at the VMA’s ? You’re in the big leagues now baby, and you bet I’m going to be with you every step of the way.”

I flushed. “It’s not just my debut. It’s CNTR’s first time in the U.S.—I’m just a part of it.”

As if by magic, a martini appeared in her outstretched hand. Extra dry, three olives, with just the lightest spritz of vermouth—Rachel was nothing if not a creature of habit. She took a sip and grimaced, “Of course, baby! But you’re the cutest one, and the most important in my book,” she gave me her trademark pout, scarlet lips pursed and big eyes

sparkling in the low light. It was the pout that had made her famous worldwide, a mix of schoolgirl innocence and poisonous seduction. My heart melted.

“Listen, we’re celebrating a good rehearsal today. Why don’t you come join us?”

A flash suddenly blinded me and I stumbled backward, cursing.

“Heeey Jiho! How about a picture I can actually use, huh?” A man stuck a giant camera in my face. Before I could tell him off—or better yet, punch his lights out—Rachel flashed a wide smile at the lens and threw her arms around my neck, pulling me toward her. Our lips came together so hard that my teeth vibrated from the impact. Before I could pry her off, the flash popped.

“Good one! Thanks!” With a tip of his hat, the paparazzo disappeared into the crowd as suddenly as he’d appeared. I pushed Rachel away and wiped my mouth. A streak of her lipstick came off on my thumb. It almost looked like blood.

“Why’d you have to put on a show like that?”

“First rule of showbiz, Oppa? Always give the people what they want,” she smiled, but there wasn’t a hint of warmth in it. “Now our kiss will be all over Dispatch, and everyone will forget about that stupid barista. Out with the old, in with the new. You’re welcome.”

Rachel didn’t wait for my response, running up to Shin and jumping on him with another shrill Oppa! I followed a beat behind, a queasy knot turning in my stomach. Mr. Song probably wouldn’t care about a little PDA, and she was probably right, this was the kind of thing that would push the whole barista business to the backburner.

But why did I feel so uncomfortable about it?

Hana

By the time I got back to my ramshackle apartment in Astoria, it was already verging on 1 p.m. Unsurprisingly, none of my three roommates seemed out and about. Amir's door was still shut, as was Zoë's, meaning the three were probably still asleep. I tiptoed past their rooms trying to get to my room that I shared with Emily, a girl in my program at NYU. I hoped she was out studying—I wanted to slip in undetected.

“Hey! Stop right there, Hana Kyung!”

Busted. Emily emerged from the kitchen, brandishing a spatula covered in scrambled eggs. Bits flew off the end and stuck to the wall, adding to the mosaic of dried food stains that never seemed to quite come off, no matter how hard I scrubbed.

“You know rent's due today, right?”

“Yeah, of course.” I laughed nervously. The living room and the bathroom were barely a couple feet apart. If I sprinted, I just might be able to make it before Emily could catch me.

“So?”

“So what?” I snapped, shuffling slowly toward the hall.

“Are you going to pay it?” She said slowly, in a tone fit for a small, dim-witted child.

“Yes, yes, my paycheck should be arriving soon so I'll have it to you by the end of the day. But if I don't get to the bathroom right now, we're going to have a bigger problem on our hands.”

“Looks like you’re going to have to wait,” she smirked. I looked up just in time to see the bathroom door close, cutting off my escape route.

A scream built in my chest. This is what I was paying over five hundred dollars a month for? Three roommates that apparently didn’t understand the concept of cleaning, a tiny closet of a bathroom, a microwave that never worked, and the smell. Oh, the mysterious smell that seemed to emanate from everywhere and nowhere at once, as if the walls themselves were soaked in it.

“Screw this.” I pushed past Emily but staggered back out immediately, pinching my nose to try and protect myself from the disgusting fumes. “What the hell? What are you cooking in there?”

“It’s not me!” She jabbed her finger at the overflowing trash can. “No one takes out the damn garbage around here.”

“Why can’t you do it?” I shot back. She looked as shocked as if I’d asked her to go solve world hunger instead of walking down the hall to drop a bag into a chute.

“I’m cooking!”

“Fine! Fine, I’ll do it.”

Nose still safely plugged, I gingerly grabbed the bag and held it as far as I could in front of me. It bulged ominously. I booked it down to the garbage chute, but the overfull bag was far too big to fit into the tiny rusted opening. Frustrated, I elbowed it as hard as I could and a fountain of something thick and lumpy sprayed all down my front. I howled and stumbled backward. Large chunks of sour milk plopped onto the floor.

The scream that had been building and building inside me finally ripped from my lungs. My vision blurred and I kicked the stupid chute shut. The door, weakened from years of disrepair and misuse, shivered and the handle clanged to the ground.

A disapproving tut-tut came from behind me. The mousy landlord peered around my shoulder at the mess I'd made.

"The cost to fix that will be coming out of your rent, Ms. Kyung."

Great.

Jiho

"I should get a 'Leader of the Year' award for this," I muttered, wincing as I stepped into the airy, sunlit rehearsal space. All those drinks from last night were doing the mambo on my nerves, but I'd forced myself out of bed at the crack of dawn to go grab Doyoon one of his beloved artisanal coffees (although I'd made sure to go somewhere completely new this time).

The earthy smell of freshly roasted brew tickled my nose and my stomach churned something fierce. Of all the drinks to like, of course Doyoon would choose the one that smells like a chimney and tasted like the wrong end of a cigarette. Still, something about Doyoon's expression yesterday made alarm bells go off in my head—the sooner I talked to him, the better I'd feel.

I stopped in front of his dressing room, mentally running through the bullet points in my head. I know you've been having a hard time lately, the rehearsals have been tough, I'm a little home sick too...

Oh, screw it. I yanked the door open with a hearty hello before stopping dead in my tracks.

The room was empty. Not the busy kind of empty that hinted their occupant might be back any moment, but the sterile kind of empty. Everything was spotless, not even a

crumpled piece of paper or an old coffee cup in sight. I touched the lightbulbs in the vanity. Ice cold.

Chills ran down my spine. He couldn't have...

The door slammed open behind me. "Jiho! Where's Doyoon?"

The chills solidified into ice. "How would I know?"

"Doyoon left me a message he was with you," Junghoon panted.

I gestured around the empty room mockingly, "Clearly, not true," I said. "But if he's not with you and not with me...then where the hell is he?"

Episode 6

Jiho

Loud voices echoed down the hallway behind us. Junghoon and I stood frozen in place, gaping at each other.

"You must have some idea where he is. You're the damn leader! You're supposed to keep them in line!" Spit flew from Junghoon's mouth, while his face had turned an ugly red, making him look like a dokgaebi, the ugly goblins from our fairy tales.

"Don't you think I know that?" I snapped. "What about you? You're our manager!"

Junghoon opened his mouth, probably to give me the verbal beatdown of the century, when Shin came bursting in.

“I’ve been trying to reach you fools for the past hour!” he said. “Why even have phones if you’re not going to use them?”

“Not now,” we said in unison.

Shin raised an eyebrow. “Okay, so I guess neither of you care that Doyoon’s gone back to Seoul?”

“He did what?” I yelped, spinning around so fast the damn tea nearly sloshed all over my designer hoodie.

“No, no,” Shin said, waving his hand, “clearly you’re both busy. I’ll come back...”

The bastard actually left the room, smirking at our shell-shocked expressions. Junghoon came to his senses first, roaring, “Come back here, you silver-haired brat!”

Shin popped his head back through the doorway. “But I thought you said, ‘Not now.’”

“What are you talking about? Doyoon can’t be in Seoul. He’s supposed to be here, rehearsing! When did he say he was coming back?”

“Wait, who’s gone to Seoul?” Great. Now ZT was here.

Strangled yelps were leaking out of Junghoon. His knees gave way and he sunk onto the floor on his hands and knees, small drops falling from his downturned face. “Oh my god. Oh god, this is it. I’m absolutely done for. My career is dead. What the hell am I supposed to tell the people at the VMAs?”

He gasped, breaking out into hiccups. “What am I going to tell Mr. Song?”

This wasn't too far off from what I was thinking as well. Visions of Mr. Song flying to New York to personally chop my head off with a blunt knife danced around my brain. I wouldn't put it past him.

"Hey, hey! Why didn't anyone tell me we were having a secret meeting? Trying to vote me off the island, eh?" An undercurrent of insecurity ran through LEO's light-hearted swagger as he strolled into the room.

Shin huffed impatiently, "Not everything's about you. Seems like ol' Doyoon's voted himself out."

LEO's eyes widened as he took in the completely spotless dressing room. "Whoa. Like, left left?"

"That's what we're trying to find out!" Junghoon whimpered. "This is so bad. Mr. Song is going to kill me and bury my body in the swamp where no one will find me and fifty years from now someone will solve my murder in one of those unsolved crime shows."

While Shin tried to calm Junghoon down before he could strangle himself with his own tie ("It'll be faster if I do it myself!"), I stepped into a quiet corner to try Doyoon's cell. No answer. I tried again. Straight to voicemail.

I considered just hanging up and trying again, but a flash of white-hot rage coursed through me. I raised the phone to my ear.

"It's me, you selfish bastard. Do you know what you've just done? You screwed us all, thanks to your petty personal problems. Go to hell."

"Doyoon...he's coming back right?" This from LEO, who for once sounded every bit as young as he was. I forgot sometimes underneath all those jokes and bluster he was just another teenage boy who was a little in over his head. We all were sometimes.

When no one answered, ZT finally voiced the question that'd been hanging over all of us.

“What happens if he doesn't?”

Doyoon

The skyscrapers turned into pinpricks, then nothing at all as we disappeared into the clouds. All the worries that had followed me to New York, all the problems I'd agonized over, seemed so small up here, thousands of meters in the air.

Free as a bird. For the first time, I truly understood what that meant. For the first time in weeks—no, months—I could finally breathe.

The gnawing guilt in my stomach for letting my group down aside, it was a perfect moment. It wasn't like I hadn't tried to tell the guys. I'd tried a thousand times to tell them, especially Jiho, that I wasn't happy and was ready to leave. I almost managed to spit it out yesterday during practice after the rabid fans practically tore us apart by the limbs. It had all seemed so senseless.

I shuddered at the thought of holding that much power over another human being. The words I said, the food I ate, even the very way I held my fork, was dissected to death.

Jiho's disdainful eyes, cold and impersonal, as he shrugged off the fight yesterday came to me in a flash. I could never be like that. All I'd ever wanted from life was music. A place to sing and dance. Maybe even a kid I could teach some moves to, a wife that smelled like home.

Not this. I spied a girl two seats ahead of me sneakily angling for a photo. I slid deeper into my seat, tugging my hoodie down so far it almost obscured my nose.

The guys wouldn't have understood. LEO, with his heartbreaking good looks and easy confidence, was born for stardom. ZT, quiet and brooding, had an unshakable charisma that made him stand apart without even trying. Shin was brash, but he was the kind of unstoppable force that would more easily break the world than have it break him. And Jiho...

Jiho had it all. The good looks, the charm, the drive—not only that, he shone with this indescribable aura that we all wanted but couldn't quite get. He was as bright as a flame and just as unpredictable. How could I have told them how difficult it was to be a regular person when the whole world was looking for you to be something extraordinary?

Every day that passed I was less “Doyoon” and more “what the fans wanted Doyoon to be.”

They never had to be anyone different to be loved by the adoring crowd. LEO, the seductive playboy. ZT, the cold and mysterious one. Shin, the energetic everything-man. Jiho, the dark Prince. And me? Who would love me as I was, the regular guy who'd rather spend the day eating Shin ramen and vegging out in sweatpants than going to Milan or traveling the world with a hot supermodel girlfriend?

So, I made a persona. The sweet, sensitive one. The angelic do-gooder that all the ahjummas couldn't get enough of—“Oh, he's a good boy!”

At first, the plastic smile didn't quite fit on my face, sliding off during meet-and-greets or during selfies. But as time went on, the fake “Doyoon” started becoming easier and easier to put on, until I could no longer tell who the real me was. If I didn't get out now, I might lose myself forever. No matter how hard it might be to leave now, it was my only option.

I sighed. How was I going to explain this to my parents? Hopefully, by the time I arrived in Korea, they would be waking up in Sydney and I'd be able to catch them before they could hear the news from anyone else.

Fly faster, I silently begged the pilot. Get me home.

Hana

It took an hour of scrubbing my body raw in boiling hot water before I finally felt clean enough to meet Eunji for dinner. Even then, the smell of sour milk seemed to float around me like a cloud and Eunji wrinkled her nose, pulling back immediately from our hug.

“Ew, you smell like a garbage dump.”

“Don’t get me started.” I held up two fingers to the proprietor of the little dumpling shop. She nodded and got to work on our orders.

“Let me guess. Emily? Again?”

“It’s not just her. It’s living with three roommates in an awful, small apartment. The landlord saw the garbage chute door fall off in my hands and do you know what she did?” Eunji shook her head, and I continued. “She told me I had to pay for any damages! I don’t even have a crappy job to pay for my equally crappy apartment, so I might not even be able to afford that soon.”

An earsplitting shriek came from the next table over. I nearly jumped out of my seat.

“Doyoon! No!” Actual, honest-to-God tears were streaming down the girl’s face. We turned to watch a reporter on TV announcing Doyoon’s sudden departure from New York and maybe CNTR, and Eunji gasped. As the reporter listed out the known reasons for his exit (personal, of course), equally distraught girls in black outfits could be seen clutching each other and sobbing behind her.

I rolled my eyes, “God, why is everyone so obsessed with them? It’s not like they’re royalty.”

Eunji hushed me, eyes glued to the screen. “Where have you been the past two years? CNTR’s the hottest thing since EXO. They are royalty.”

“Pfft,” I waved at her dismissively. “They’re okay, I guess. Besides, any group that the guy who got me fired is in, is automatically on my shit list. Sorry.”

Even if it was a really hot, really talented guy.

“I know, I agree with you that it was wrong of Jiho to do,” Eunji said quickly. “But don’t blame the whole group for it! Doyoon is a sweetheart!”

“I literally could care less about CNTR, Jiji,” I rubbed my hands over my face. “If I don’t get a job ASAP, I’m going to get evicted. That’s what I care about, not some boy band.”

Eunji’s phone chirped, and she tapped the screen to check on the notification. I peered out at her through my fingers, sighing pitifully.

“Hello? Earth to best friend? Kind of in the middle of a full-on mental breakdown here?”

This time Eunji ignored me completely, typing something furiously into her phone. I sighed and popped dumpling after dumpling into my mouth, snatching some from her plate in petty revenge. Half the table was clear by the time she looked up.

“Oh? Remembered I was here?”

“I just got an alert from CenU.”

“That stupid CNTR fan café?” I asked. “You’re choosing to ignore your soon-to-be-homeless best friend for your fan site?”

“It looks like they’re holding tryouts to find a replacement to take Doyoon’s place at the VMA’s.

“Oh my god, you’re just as bad as that girl over there.” The girl shot me a dirty look, which I promptly ignored, “Who cares, Jiji?”

“You should care,” she said, holding out her screen for me to see. A cartoon version of Jiho scowled at me from the screen, holding a giant text bubble proclaiming, “You’re in!”

“What do you mean?” I asked. “Why?”

Eunji grinned. “Because I just entered you as a participant!”

Episode 7

Hana

The very next morning, I invited Eunji—and at her insistence, Miles from my dance crew—over for an emergency war tribunal before the auditions. We stood huddled in the walk-in closet I shared with three of my roommates. Eunji threw a beat-up pair of sweatpants at me in disgust, purposely shoving her fingers in the holes and wiggling them around.

“I cannot believe we are best friends,” she muttered, gingerly picking through my sad stack of equally threadbare clothes. Next to her glamorous top that she’d made herself from recycled silk, they did kind of look like rags.

“It’s not like I’m getting dressed for dinner with the queen here. It’s just an audition. Why can’t I go in what I usually wear?” I held up a pair of slightly stretched out secondhand leggings and a cropped hoodie I’d found at Goodwill. Eunji wrinkled her nose.

“No way! I’m burning those before I leave, I hope you know.”

Miles shrugged, “You could wear what you did when we won regionals?”

My annoyance melted slightly at his sweetly boyish face. It was like trying to stay annoyed at a puppy dog.

“Yeah, that might be a good idea. It’s not like what I wear matters anyway. This isn’t exactly New York amateur dance fest—no offense, Miles,” I added quickly. He laughed, flashing his pearly whites.

“None taken. As much as I love our NYU dance club, we’re pennies compared to CNTR. I’ve never seen anyone dance like those guys do,” he shook his head, amazed.

“I still can’t believe you roped me into this. As if I know the first thing about K-pop—even Miles knows CNTR better than I do!”

Eunji mumbled something distractedly, eyes glued to her phone. CeNTR Universe—BECAUSE THEY’RE THE CENTER OF OUR UNIVERSE, jumped out in big block letters.

“Seriously?” I wadded up a pile of my shirts and threw it at her. “How do you not get tired of that fan site? I bet you’ve read every single post by now.”

“I don’t get mad over the things you love, like unfashionable clothes,” she retorted, tearing her eyes away from the screen long enough to stick her tongue out at me. “You might actually be interested in this. Doyoon-oppa apparently specifically requested for a fan to take his place at the awards because, quote, ‘they will be the only people to appreciate the experience and the group the way they should be appreciated.’”

She sighed, eyelashes fluttering as she clutched the phone to her chest directly over her heart. “Isn’t he the cutest? Oppa, saranghae! I love you!”

“I don’t think he can hear you,” I snorted. Miles chuckled, poorly distinguishing his chortles as coughs at Eunji’s death glare.

“Don’t you start on me, too! I can’t believe you guys aren’t touched by this,” she said. “What kind of celebrity actually cares for his fans this much?”

“Trust me babe, all I care about right now is not making a complete fool of myself. I still can’t believe you signed me up without asking!” I tugged ruefully at my holey sweatpants. They’d been patched so many times that it was more hole than pant at this point. Miles reached out for me but seemingly changed his mind at the last minute, playfully bumping my knees with his foot instead.

“Stop thinking like that. Even if you don’t get in, it’s an amazing opportunity. Think of all the scouts that could be watching the audition! Who knows, you might get a call to dance for Beyoncé or something tomorrow.”

I glanced at Miles and his big, blue sparkling eyes. So sure of a future that could be built on dreams. He’s never had to fight for anything, a wicked voice whispered in my ear.

I excused myself to change into the outfit Miles had suggested, but mostly to hide the frown on my face.

“I’ve said this before and I’ll say it again—dancing’s not secure and it definitely doesn’t pay enough,” I said. “Not at first. I need something stable.”

“Like psychology? Yeah, real stable,” Eunji taunted. “And boring.” I reached around the door to give her the middle finger.

There wasn’t enough room in the closet for a mirror, so I did my best to adjust my joggers and braid my hair in a way that looked more “cool-and-carefree” than “sloppy-and-grungy.”

“Okay!” I called out. “I’m ready.”

A muffled cheer, some hushed fumbling, then the first strains of CNTR’s “100 Percent” filtered through the door.

“Step right up, contestant number four!” Miles boomed in his best approximation of a TV show host. I squeezed my eyes shut and strode out into the room, throwing up my hands and giving them a good twirl. When I opened them, Miles’s mouth was open in a surprised little “o,” his gaze soft.

“You look—wow. I mean, amazing. Y-you look amazing.”

He turned as red as a tomato. There was a beat of awkward silence before Eunji clapped sharply.

“Enough flirting!” she said. “You’ve got some auditions to kill!”

Jiho

What a difference a day can make. Here we were, all five—no, four—of us, crowded in the same rehearsal space that we’d basically lived in for the past couple of weeks, and the mood couldn’t have been more different. All the laughter, the inside jokes, the play wrestling were gone.

The air felt heavy. Only Shin and LEO were talking in hushed whispers. I don’t know why they bothered—we could all hear Doyoon’s name from the snatches of their conversation, clear as day.

“Mind sharing with the class?” I drawled. They slunk back to the rest of the group, shamefaced.

“I was just saying to ZT that you should let me pick someone from the contest,” Shin said, trying and failing to look nonchalant as he picked a piece of lint off his Burberry jacket. “You know me, I’ve got a natural eye for talent. Just let me head up this thing.”

LEO threw back his head and laughed. “As if we need another Shin 2.0! We’d have to make the doorway bigger so both your heads could fit.”

“What makes you think I’d pick somebody like me?” Shin retorted.

“Easy. You’re a narcissist. You don’t think anyone is good enough to be in our group other than you.”

Shin considered this for a second, then shrugged. “Fair enough.”

I held my hand up in the air and the rest of the guys fell silent. “I know you’re just messing around, but this contest isn’t a joke, all right? It was all Mr. Song’s idea and he wants it executed perfectly.”

The dreaded call from the CEO had come only minutes after Shin had burst in with the news that Doyoon had left. Junghoon and I had answered the phone together, and when Junghoon’s voice gave out I was the one who pitched in to finish the story. The other line had been silent for so long, the coffee I’d brought for Doyoon that morning had turned ice cold in my hand before Mr. Song said a single word.

When he did, there wasn’t a single trace of the kind, fatherly figure he liked to portray himself as. His voice was soft, but his words sliced me deep, like shards of ice, “Do you remember what I told you, Jiho?”

“Yes, sir,” I croaked out.

“And what did I tell you?”

“That our performance at the VMAs must be perfect.”

“And that, as the leader of the team, it was your responsibility that every member of the group was at the top of their game. Isn’t that what I said?”

“Yes, sir. I know this was my responsibility, sir.”

Another long pause. Junghoon shook so hard, the phone jangled in his hands. My knee bobbed uncontrollably. The silence thickened, so hot with anticipation that a flush rose in my cheeks. Finally, a sigh released us.

“Very well, then. What’s done is done. Now listen very carefully—here’s how we fix this.”

I repeated Mr. Song’s instructions to the other members, word for word. “A contest for fans only will create so much buzz that it’ll force out all our negative press.”

Shin glanced at the coffee cup in his hand, then back at me. I chose to ignore him.

“Not to mention, we can strengthen our U.S. fan base by auditioning Americans, driving up viewers right before the VMAs. Then boom! We cinch it all up with a killer performance and go back home as heroes.”

“Yeah, but who decides who wins?” ZT broke in.

The telltale creak of a door opening came from behind. A kid, no older than any of us, strolled over to us, both hands in his pockets, cool as you please. He didn’t bow as he came in, an unthinkable show of disrespect to his elders.

My heart sank. It couldn't be...

"Uh, excuse me? Can't you read?" LEO waved one hand at the "Closed for Private Session" sign. I shoved past him.

"Song Youngdo? What are you doing here?" I asked, looking at the man in the suit before us. "How'd you convince your father to let you come to America by yourself?"

The unspoken question of Is he with you? hung between us. The seki didn't bother answering me.

"Hyung, who is this guy?" ZT bristled.

LEO shrugged. "C'mon, don't get all worked up over it. He's probably one of those rude-ass delivery boys. Are you here to pick up our lunch orders? I'm feeling like some fried chicken," he said. Youngdo towered over him with his 182 centimeter frame. His lip curled.

"Shut up! Show some respect." Shin, cheeks red, smacked the back of LEO's head. "Don't you fools recognize who this is? It's Mr. Song's son!"

Silence. The blood drained out of ZT and LEO's faces as realization dawned on them.

"Oh shit! I'm so sorry, Youngdo-nim," LEO stuttered, using the polite form usually reserved for those of higher status or advanced age. "I didn't recognize you with your new haircut. Please don't tell Mr. Song?"

Youngdo ignored him completely, addressing just me, Shin, and Junghoon in his bored drawl.

“I flew all the way from Seoul to oversee the contest,” Youngdo said in his deep voice. “I will be the one who decides who wins.”

Hana

The line for the audition wrapped around the block twice. An odd feeling came over me as I scanned the faces of my competition. Miles’s banged-up beater of a Nissan roared ominously as we parked in the first available spot, nearly a mile away. Suddenly, I realized what had been bothering me.

“Eunji!” I hissed, grabbing her arms so hard she flinched. “All the people here are guys!”

She shrugged me off, rubbing her arm ruefully as we took our place in line. “Maybe CNTR has a lot of secret guy fans? I’ll check.”

She rummaged through her bag, nose deep into her fan café forums within seconds. Miles gave me a quick side hug. Did I imagine his hand ghosting my back for a second? “Don’t worry, kid. None of them stand a chance against you. Take it from someone who’s seen you on stage and knows what you’re capable of.”

Despite my mixed feelings about Miles, I leaned into the comforting warmth of his hug. The heat radiating off his body was irresistible and my stomach did backflips.

“Oh, shit.” Eunji’s face fell. She glanced at me nervously, chewing her bottom lip the way she did when she really messed up, like the time she’d taken her dad’s Jeep for a joy ride to the bottom of a lake.

“What?”

“Please, please don’t kill me.”

“Just tell me!”

Wordlessly, Eunji passed me her phone and I snatched it, scrolling through the audition rules. “It looks fine to me.”

She moaned. “Look at the bottom of the page. They have all the terms and conditions in this itsy-bitsy font.”

I read out loud: “All entrants must be men.”

The three of us froze. The sound that ripped from my throat was more animal than human. “Are you kidding me? Eunji, you’re the one that dragged me out here!” I was shaking “This was all your idea! How could you not know I had to be a guy to enter?”

“But that part of the rules is written so small, and it’s all the way down at the bottom—” Catching the look on my face, she hurriedly added, “Okay, I didn’t read any of it. Happy?”

“No!” I shrieked, shoving her phone back at her. “What a waste of time. I could have been looking for a real job this whole time. You know I don’t have time to be screwing around like this.”

This is what you get for dreaming, a little voice whispered in my ear. I looked desperately around. “Maybe Miles could audition in my place?”

“No way. I’m sorry, but you know I’m not into K-pop like that,” he said. He did seem really sorry about it, his big teddy bear eyes brimming with sympathy. It just made me even angrier. How dare he feel bad for me?

“As if I’m into any of this stuff either!” I shouted so loudly a couple of the guys in line around us turned to glare. “You know what? I’m out of here.”

I nearly ran back to Miles’s clunker, tears stinging my eyes. Before I could hide myself in the back seat, a small hand clamped on my shoulder, turning me to face a breathless Eunji.

“No. You’re not going anywhere. I promised you an audition and you’re going to get an audition,” Eunji said. “I have an idea.”

Episode 8

Hana

I threw up my hands. “How? How do you have an idea of how to fix this?” I asked my best friend. “If you haven’t noticed, I don’t quite fit the description!”

A mischievous look I knew all too well crept over her face. I gulped. “Yeah, I know that but the judges don’t. And I know how to make sure they never find out. Do you remember when I helped out at my high school production of that Shakespeare play, whatchamacallit—”

“As You Like It?” Miles, who’d finally caught up to us, finished for her.

She crowed. “Yes! That’s the one. Anyway, there was this whole scene where the heroine, Rosalind, turns herself into a shepherd boy and guess who was in charge of the costumes?”

“You?” She nodded enthusiastically. “Great story, but what does this have to do with me?”

Miles nudged me in the side. “She’s saying she can pull off this whole Rosalind transformation on you.”

Eunji smiled beatifically at him. “I knew I liked you.”

“You’re both losing it. In case you’ve both forgotten, this is a super public audition! If I manage to scam my way past the prelims, the next round will be livestreamed to fans all over the world,” I said. “People from Seoul all the way to Timbuktu will be watching. Not to mention all the potential legal or ethical problems if they end up finding out.”

“Hana, they’ll pay you at least a thousand dollars just for one performance.” The smile disappeared from Eunji’s face as she gripped my arm, hard. We both knew just how desperately I needed the money and how low my chances were of finding another thousand before my rent was due.

“Oh my god, I can’t believe I’m actually considering you and your crazy idea right now.”

Sensing her opening, Eunji pressed on. “You just need to win and make it to the live broadcast, then you’ll get that fat stack of cash and we’ll never have to talk about CNTR ever again.”

“Promise?” I said weakly, and we chuckled. “Assuming the judges don’t kick me off the stage, how do you expect me to win and get to the live broadcast?”

“I don’t know! You’re the dancer! But one thing I do know is that I’m going to be right there with you. We’ll figure something out. You need that thousand more than any of the other people in line.”

I took a deep breath to steel myself. Whatever happened would happen, but the stark reality of the situation was that if I didn’t pull a thousand dollars out of a hat now, I’d be out on the streets. Potentially making a fool of myself in front of a handful of people didn’t seem so bad when I pictured myself roaming the alleys of New York, dumpster-diving for scraps in the middle of the night.

“You’re right. But...are you absolutely sure we can pull this off?”

Soft arms and Eunji's rose-tinged scent enveloped me and I breathed in deep. It felt like home. "There's only one way to find out."

Jiho

The little brat. I was furious, ready to rip that cocky smile off of Youngdo's face.

"No. No way am I going to let a guy like you have the final say on who makes it in," I said. "CNTR is mine."

It was my baby. I'd sweated for it, fought for it, worked day and night until my toenails had fallen off and I couldn't stand up straight without pain shooting through my entire body...and this seki thought he'd fly in and take it all away because of who his dad was? No way was I going to let that happen.

Youngdo snorted. "Wake up Jiho. DJ entertainment is my company. Therefore, everything it owns is mine, even this group."

I barked out a savage laugh. "This is your father's company, not yours. You're just some guy who rode in on your famous father's coattails."

His interminable sneer wavered. Electricity crackled in the air as we stared each other down.

"I just want to put it out there that I'll dance with anyone as long as they don't steal any of my close-ups." Shin broke in.

“Why do we even have to replace Doyoon? Can’t we just change the moves around a little to fill the gap...sir?” ZT added hastily when Youngdo turned his cold stare at him.

“You’re such a bahbo,” LEO huffed. “Doyoon was the best dancer in the group, we can’t just drop his part. He had so many cool solos, the set would look weird without him.”

“Precisely,” Youngdo put in crisply. “Doyoon’s replacement has to be perfect—this is the VMAs. That’s why I’ll be the one deciding who will fill in.”

“Then you’d better be prepared to replace me, too.” The words slipped out of my mouth before I could stop them, but the surprise that broke through Youngdo’s mask of condescension was worth it. “If I don’t approve of the winner, I’ll be on the next plane back to Seoul just like Doyoon, I can promise you that.”

“Stop it!” Junghoon said. Our manager, who’d always had the nervous temperament of a squirrel, looked like he was mere seconds away from exploding into a million little, stressed-out pieces. “Can we please stop fighting? If we don’t figure something out the producers of the VMAs will want my head on a platter!”

Shin scoffed. “That’s not really our problem, though, is it?”

Junghoon stood up, fire in his eyes, “Listen up. We’re going to have to compromise. I think I have a way.”

Hana

The tiny closet we’d found near the entrance of the auditorium was too dark to see properly, and Eunji had to shine her cell phone flashlight directly into my eyes to put on the final few touches. We’d left Miles outside to guard the door and to deter prying eyes.

My chest was pretty flat to begin with and I didn't mind dressing androgynously either, but Eunji was taking me a step further.

I didn't hate it. I actually felt really good.

"Damn Jiji, you weren't exaggerating about your styling skills."

"See? What did I tell you? Always trust your Eunji."

"The shirt's way too big though," I said, gingerly holding up the giant crewneck that draped over me like a sail. "I might trip over it on stage,"

"Oh, don't be dramatic. You're lucky Miles had an extra tee in his car at all." She closed her compact, a funny look in her eyes while her mouth pursed in thought. "Face is done. Now we've got to do something about this hair..."

She rummaged through her makeup bag and withdrew a sharp, gleaming pair of scissors. Their wide jaws were lined with wicked teeth that glinted demonically in the bright beam of her flashlight. I cringed as far backward as I could within the cramped quarters.

"No way. No way you are cutting my hair in the dark." I ran my hands through my hair. It was only brushing my shoulders as it was. "Don't you have a wig or something?"

"Nope!" With my back against the wall, I couldn't do much other than try and cover my head as she marched over, brandishing her weapon of destruction. She easily brushed my hands away and swept up my mane of hair. The cold steel of the scissors brushed the nape of my neck as a telltale snip-snip filled my ears. Short chunks tickled my jawline as hunks of hair fell softly to my feet, my mouth agape in horror.

"What did you do?"

Eunji brushed what was left of my long tresses back, snipping here and there before leaning back, satisfied. “Don’t freak out so much. It looks good! A whole new Hana Kyung. You know, some salons on the Upper East Side would charge you hundreds for a cut like this.”

I lunged and grabbed a fistful of her beautiful, balayage-d bangs, trying to snatch the scissors away. Girly-girl that she was, Eunji went down with a thud.

“Hey guys, I think they’re calling everyone to the stage!” Miles whispered through the crack.

“Showtime!” She pushed me off and brandished a tiny hand mirror. I turned my head this way and that, whimpering over the loss of my trusty ponytail. Oh, what I’d do to Eunji after this was over...

“No time for that,” Miles hustled me out the door and into the hall.

“But do I really look like a K-pop idol?” I asked as we ran through the hallway to the stage together.

He glanced over at me, pausing momentarily to take in my new bob, before nodding, “A very pretty boy. You’ll be so far away from the judges on the stage, don’t worry. Just do your best. Now go!”

Before I could argue or change my mind or do anything other than stutter out a meek protest, the throng of other contestants had swept me away.

Here went nothing.

Episode 9

Hana

The river of bodies carried me to the stage, where a production assistant was reading out names one by one. She paused for a second, brows furrowed as she called out, “Hana Kyung?”

Oh God. It’s going wrong already. I craned my neck, searching for an exit when a confident voice rang out above the confused murmurs that were waiting for the person to stop holding up the check-in.

“Actually, that’s a typo. His real name is Haneul. With an E-U-L.”

Eunji! There was no one else it could be. I swiveled around to see her grinning cheekily at me just a couple steps away.

I was going to kill her when this was over.

“Sure, whatever,” the assistant said. “Just go up to the side of the stage and wait there until somebody calls your name.”

I followed a couple of other guys up to the wing. Several of them were practicing their pop and locks, a couple were buried in their phones, and still others were gathered in small groups, chatting in low voices. One of these guys broke off his conversation when I came close. His face was vaguely familiar, probably a dancer from the New York circuit I’d competed against in the past. My heart nearly stopped.

Have I been found out already?

But he just snorted at me derisively, after giving me a cool once-over. “You might as well drop out now. You can’t compete with me.”

The rest of the guys goaded him on with a couple friendly boos.

“Bet you can’t even dance!” One of them hooted.

“Way better than you!” To prove his point, he went straight from a standing backflip into a perfect windmill. I whistled. The guy might be a Grade A asshole, but there was no denying he had some skills.

Not better than me, though. I didn’t even realize I’d said it out loud until the room erupted with a chorus of wolf whistles. The asshole’s face turned red.

“What’d you say to me, punk?”

“He just said what we were all thinking.” Another dancer, dressed head-to-toe in B-boy gear, said. B-Boy and Asshole squared off, each puffing their chests up. The air was thick with tension.

I slunk as far away from the dick-measuring contest as I could. I’d seen some of this male posturing before at dance tournaments, but it had always been from a distance. I can’t wait until this is over.

The PA from before stuck her head out from the curtains, listing off names lightning fast. B-Boy and Asshole, along with a handful of others, followed her into the blinding light of the waiting stage.

I crept closer, trying to peek through the dusty velvet curtains at what was going down. Some CNTR song boomed over the loudspeakers, and the choreographer flipped through a complicated set of moves so quickly that his feet were a blur. Most of the guys on stage gave each other confused looks, but each step was burned into my brain.

Some people had photographic memory. My dance teacher in elementary school used to say I had “dance-o-graphic” memory. I’d never been so grateful for my seemingly useless talent. I was definitely going to need every ounce of it here.

Doyoon

When I finally got off the plane fourteen hours later, eyes drooping from having stayed up through the entire trip, the only thing I could think of was getting somewhere safe. Somewhere calm, with no ogling fans or paparazzi to worry about.

I yawned so loudly, my jaw cracked. Need to find somewhere to sleep.

Incheon International airport was huge, but I did my best to be as inconspicuous as possible. My sunglasses were up and my face down, complete with a face mask. Just like Jiho had taught me.

My phone rang. Speak of the devil.

Jiho's name lit up the screen. I let it ring until the phone finally went silent. What time was it where he was? My alerts blinked up at me: Jiho—10 missed calls. Shit.

My hand shook as I scrolled through all my notifications. Everyone I'd so much as talked to at a party or shook hands with had tried to call me since last night. People I hadn't heard from in years were sending me frantic messages—are you okay? What's going on? Call me!

This was the last thing I wanted right now. First sleep, then I'd deal with all my problems.

Sorry, Jiho-hyung. I'll call you later, I promised him silently.

By sheer chance I managed to make it to baggage claim without being spotted, but the babble of raised voices from the concourse told me that my luck had run out. I could just make out the chorus of “Summer, Summer” coming from the area ahead of me.

Cursing, I leaned flat against the wall and ran through all my options. Grabbing my luggage was out of the question at this point. Everything inside was replaceable. Maybe if I took the shuttle to the next terminal over, I’d be able to slip out unnoticed. Yes, that might actually work!

“Excuse me, sir.” A tall man in an immaculate suit stood in front of me as if he’d been summoned from thin air. “Doyoon-nim?”

“Yes?” I answered warily, not at all convinced he wasn’t some creepily realistic hallucination.

“Mr. Song is expecting you. Please follow me.” The man was polite, but there was an undercurrent of steel under his genteel manner. I’d been around Mr. Song long enough to know that he didn’t play around. It was a mark of how tired I was that I even tried to argue.

“I’m really sorry, but do you think it might be possible to see him tomorrow? I don’t think I’d make much sense right now, even if we did meet.”

The man’s answering smile was cold. “Would you rather have a chat with your fans, Doyoon-nim?”

I gulped at the shrieks down the hall. “Fair point. Lead the way.”

He guided me past a hidden door I hadn’t seen and down a maze of hallways, each one exactly the same as the last. I lost track of where we were before long. It felt like a long, endless nightmare of beige walls, beige doors, and glowing exit signs, my only company a man who looked like he’d walked straight out of the Men in Black movies. After what

felt like hours, an airport employee in a fluorescent neon vest ushered us through another nondescript door and we were finally outside.

The sweet smell of pre-dawn air tickled my nose and I breathed in deep. Somewhere in this city was my mother's homemade cod stew, my childhood friends, and most important, my soft, down bed.

"Come." The tall man hurried me to a sleek black SUV that was idling across the street. I stumbled in through the open door and came face-to-face with Mr. Song himself.

It never failed to surprise me how normal the boss looked. If it wasn't for the perfectly pressed Italian suit or the gleaming Rolex on his wrist, he'd look just like any other ahjushi on the street. His plain face was creased in disappointment and I felt a rush of shame at having troubled this nice man.

"Doyoon," Mr. Song said, his voice low. Disappointed. "You should have told me you were coming."

"I apologize, sir. I can assure you, none of this was planned."

"Planned or not, I must say I'm not happy to see you. Wouldn't a phone call have sufficed?" Mr. Song spread his square fingers in front of him in a mock-helpless gesture. The smell of his expensive cologne seemed to strengthen in the car. My sluggish mind fought to recall the determination I'd felt last night when I'd bought my plane ticket home, but everything felt hazy and muddled now.

"I—I'm sorry, sir, but I just had to get away. The group—I was forgetting—" What had I been forgetting? I couldn't shift the fog of exhaustion long enough to form a coherent thought. Mr. Song put out a well-manicured hand.

"If I were you, Doyoon, I'd pick my next words very carefully. I don't have much time, anyway. I just came to tell you in person how sorry I am."

“Sorry?” I repeated stupidly.

“Yes. I’m so sorry you had to come all this way just to go back.”

“You’re...you’re telling me to go back to New York?”

Mr. Song shrugged nonchalantly, “I told you, a phone call would have sufficed.”

Hana

“...and Haneul Kyung! Hanuel Kyung!” The PA snapped her impatient fingers in my direction.

Oh, right. That’s me.

“Sorry!” I said quickly, bolting up to the stage to join my group.

Momentarily, I was overcome by the megawatt spotlights that shone down on us from all sides. The only thing I could see were the other contestants and the choreographer. Even when I squinted, I couldn’t make out a single detail of the judges’ panel that were no doubt sitting right in front of me, dissecting my every move. Sweat beaded on my skin.

“Everyone ready?”

We all nodded, and after running through the steps once more, lightning-fast, the choreographer pointed heavenward and the music began.

I didn't know the song. I barely knew the moves. But my heart seemed to drum in time with the heavy bass as the countdown began and warmth flooded from the crown of my head to the tips of my toes.

5-6-7-8.

My eyes shut as I counted the beats to begin the sequence. One hand up, left foot back, and we were off.

The driving melody flowed through my body and I slid from the first position to the second to the third without missing a beat. All the worries that had filled my mind just moments before melted away and I was one with the music, just an empty vessel for the song to take shape. My feet stamped in anger when the singer wailed. I spun when the chorus pleaded for clarity, dizzy with anticipation for the next drop to kick in.

Suddenly, a sharp elbow stabbed me in my side and I stumbled. It was easy enough to get back into the rhythm, but just seconds later, he jostled me from the other side, forcing me to jump to the balls of my feet to keep from losing balance.

"Cut!" A sharp voice from the judges' table called out, and the music stopped abruptly. The heady euphoria that came from dancing drained out of me, and I stood on stage feeling as deflated and foolish as an empty balloon.

"Let's try this one more time. You there, in the big shirt! Make sure to stay in line this time. No third chances."

I glared at the dancer to my right. He gave me a tiny smirk before heading back to his starting position. That asshole! He totally did it on purpose!

I fought anger back with a couple of deep, cleansing breaths. It didn't matter what tricks he tried to pull; I was ten times the dancer he was. You got this. I bounced on the tips of my toes, ready to dive back into the formation.

“Wait!” Another judge called out this time. His commandeering tone was vaguely familiar. “It’s way too bright. I can barely see who’s out there.”

Immediately, the lights dimmed on stage and the silhouettes of the judges became visible, their shadowy forms slowly filling out with more details as my eyes adjusted. When I finally saw who was sitting in front of me, my knees buckled, and it took everything I had not to collapse in surprise.

Who else could it be but Jiho, looking as aloof and as arrogant as the day he’d gotten me fired?

Shit. What if he recognizes me?

Episode 10

Hana

What I’d give to just jump off the stage and punch the bored expression right off that arrogant asshole’s face!

“Better,” Jiho said as the lights dimmed. “Thanks.”

If he recognized me, he didn’t show it.

“All right, let’s go again from the chorus,” the choreographer said. The music started up again and the first catchy refrains boomed from the sound system in no time at all. “Five, six, seven, eight.”

Somehow, I managed to move my numb feet through the first couple of counts, my shock slowly replaced by an anger that was building steadily with every driving beat.

You did this! I wanted to scream at Jiho. You're the reason I'm up here and days away from being evicted from my apartment! You're the reason I'm out here dancing for my life!

My hits got harder, my steps more sure and quick. I didn't take my eyes off Jiho for a second, letting the sight of him drive power into each of my moves. The rest of the crowd melted away. It was just me and him and the music.

See? See how good I am? I thought. This is what I can do. This is the person you treated like the dirt beneath your shoes. They're as good as you.

I was light. I was air. None of the other dancers, not even the one who'd nearly tripped me up before, could get close to me. I leaped away from them, my feet barely touching the ground before I sprang up into the next complicated series of windmills, pops, and locks.

"Yeah, you left me for dead but look at me now!" The singer wailed over the loudspeaker.

Look at me now!

I was suddenly struck by the memory of Eunji showing me the music video to this very song months ago. Although their hit "Summer Summer" was light-hearted, this one was much angstier than that, with a clear rock and roll drumline. Music that was almost raw in its defiance.

The fierce joy that had shone out of the dancer's face as he'd run right up to the camera and effortlessly pulled off one of the most difficult moves I'd ever seen—with a smile on his face—was seared into my mind. Suddenly, I knew that if I was going to have a chance in hell at winning this, I'd have to do something that crazy.

Can I pull this off?

The rap refrain was almost over—the song was whipping itself into a frenzy, nearing its climax. All of us were dancing so fast, our feet were a blur. The ground beneath us was getting slick with sweat.

“Look at me now! Look. At. Me. Now!” the refrain continued.

I ran downstage toward the judges’ table, staring straight at Jiho as I flawlessly executed a double backflip into a one-handed handstand, my other hand holding desperately onto the shirt to keep it from falling down. I held the pose for the last few, excruciating beats.

Then it was over. No one said a word. I slowly straightened up, suddenly nervous that I’d ruined my only shot.

The judges leaned over each other to deliberate, whispering softly beneath their cupped hands. Eunji and Miles had somehow snuck into the audience area behind them and they both gave me enthusiastic waves over Jiho’s head. Jiho was clearly arguing with one of the other judges, his brow furrowed as he shook his head emphatically.

Jiho

The never-ending flow of contestants all seemed to blend in together. Short, fat, tall, skinny—what did it matter? There were only a couple that I’d even consider to dance back-up for us, let alone join us on stage. And that was only because we were being forced to.

I checked my watch again. The hour hand was still stubbornly stuck at 3 p.m., although I could swear days had gone by since I’d last checked it. I stifled a groan. What the hell was I doing wasting precious rehearsal time auditioning talentless idiots when the VMAs were only a couple days away?

All because of stupid Doyoon. He couldn't have waited until we were all back in Seoul to pull his disappearing act?

"That one," Youngdo jabbed his pen at the skinny boy dressed in what looked like his dad's shirt. "He's the only one who tried to do Doyoon's handstand trick."

Junghoon grunted in agreement. "He's clearly a level above the others. Good stage presence. What do you think, Jiho?"

"The kid has a couple of tricks up his sleeve. Who cares?" I said. "We don't need any cocky upstarts messing with the harmony of the group by trying to upstage everyone else. I don't know why you guys are so impressed with that second-rate copycat."

"You're being argumentative on purpose. Look at him." Youngdo gestured to the guy who was drinking water on stage with the others.

I snorted. "Yeah? What about him?"

Youngdo glared at me. "He's clearly the best dancer we've seen all day, and he's got the right look." I snorted again and he sighed. "I know how much you're hoping Doyoon will come back, Jiho, but you've got to face the reality of it. He's gone, and you're going to have to pick somebody from this lot. If you can't do it, I will."

I cursed under my breath, staring down at my silent phone. Twenty missed calls later, and not a peep from Doyoon. No text, no calls back, not even a stupid emoji to show me he was still alive. This was all his fault. If only I could get a hold of him, I knew I could talk him into coming back and then we could end this charade once and for all.

"Hey. You listening to me?" Youngdo snapped and I shot up in my seat.

“Fine, pick whoever you want. It doesn’t matter who we choose, they’ll only dance with us one time anyway,” I said, shoving the chair in. “Go ahead, pick the copycat for all I care.”

I whirled out of the auditorium before Youngdo could say another word in that weaselly, nasal voice of his.

Stupid daddy’s boy.

Hana

After our audition, the PA from earlier gently shooed us back into the waiting area where we nervously waited for the results. She stopped calling out names, and no one else joined us backstage.

“Do you think this means someone was selected?” One of the dancers asked excitedly. More than one person looked at me but I just shrugged. Five minutes passed. Then ten. Then twenty. What the hell was taking so long?

What am I doing here? I suddenly felt hot. Of course, they wouldn’t pick me. I was just one of the millions of hobby dancers in New York, and most of the other competitors had clearly gotten more formal training than I could ever dream of.

Did I honestly think one flashy trick was going to change their minds? A trick of one of their own members at that. It was the one thing I always remembered from a video Eunji showed me—that guy Doyoon could dance.

It was definitely time to go. Maybe if I headed straight to the campus library, I’d be able to send off a couple of resumes before they closed for the day. I drifted over to the door, trying to surreptitiously slip out before anyone could notice I’d left.

One of the judges I didn't recognize at the table stopped me in my tracks. "Where do you think you're going? Nobody's been excused yet."

Foiled in my escape attempt, I took my hand off the doorknob. "I'm sorry, but some of us have places we have to be. I'm an adult, I can take a 'no,'" I said gruffly. "Just tell us the results and we can all be on our merry way."

A sharply dressed man approached us from the judges' table. I recognized him as the one who'd been arguing with Jiho earlier. He exuded power with every step he took, as if he owned the very stage and everybody on it.

"I understand your frustration, Hanuel, but I'm afraid I'm going to have to ask you to cancel whatever prior plans you may have had for today."

"Why?" I asked, looking him up and down. He had to be around my age. I felt myself getting a little flustered looking at him. "Who are you?"

"Youngdo Song, at your service," he said with a small nod. "All you need to know, for now, Mr. Kyung, is that you aren't going anywhere because you've officially passed this round."

My brain ground to halt. What did he just say? "I...I passed?"

A small smile played over his lips. "You did a great job this round. Keep up with that personality of yours, it definitely comes through in your dancing," he said. "As I'm sure you know, we'll be doing a livestream of the final round—I can't wait to see what surprises you come up with for us."

To my utter horror, a bright red flush stained my cheeks as I stuttered out a "thank you." Youngdo gave me another secret smile before dismissing everyone else with a single nod and walking away. I stared after his broad back, my heart beating in my throat.

“Ohmigod!” Eunji barreled into my back at full force, squealing so loud that the remaining judges flinched and covered their ears. “Oppa, I’ve been waiting for you!”

“Oppa? What are you talking...” Crap! I’d completely forgotten that I was still dressed as Haneul. I hope I didn’t give it away by staring like an idiot at Youngdo!

Doing a complicated handstand move I’d never done before, winning the qualifiers, getting all tongue-twisted...too much was happening at once. My head still in a daze, I pulled Eunji toward the refreshment table so I could grab another drink of water and hopefully make some sense of what just happened.

While reaching for the water bottles, I accidentally brushed past a glowering form. His hand shot out and grabbed my arm and I yelped, automatically twisting to try and detach myself from his grasp. It was no use—his grip was like iron. I might as well have been fighting against a wall for all the good it did me.

“Hey! Let go—” When our eyes met, all the blood drained from my face.

Jiho hissed, breath hot on my face. “I know who you are!”